

# POWER AND POLITICS

## CHAPTER\_8

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# POWER & RELATED CONCEPTS

- Power is the ~~Power~~ capacity to make others act or believe in a certain way.
- The term 'power' is often used interchangeably with synonyms authority and influence. But they are all different in several ways.
- Authority entails power, but it has more legitimacy. It is given through delegation or officially bestowed upon a person.
- Influence is the ability to change how someone else thinks or behaves based on persuasion. Unlike power, with influence, you can't impact someone's actions or behavior just by telling them to do something

# POWER & DEPENDENCY

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- Power creates dependency
- B's relationship to A when A possesses something that B requires
- E.g Resources, Information

# POWER :TYPES & SOURCES

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- ❖ **Formal Power** refers to the power that establishes because of the individual's position in an organization
- ❖ **Informal Power / Personal Power** - refers to the power that comes from an individual's unique characteristics. These are the most effective because personal skills, traits and knowledge influence personal power.



# SOURCES OF ORGANIZATIONAL POWER

## (WHERE DOES POWER COME FROM?) – FORMAL POWER

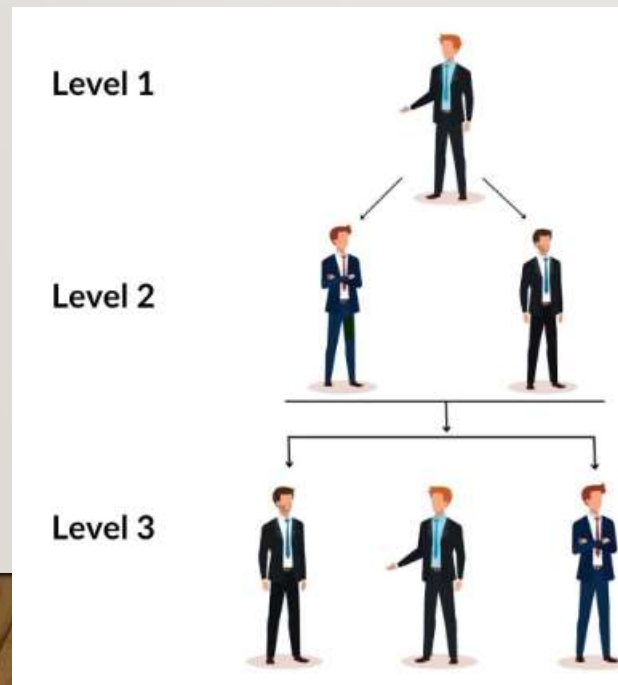
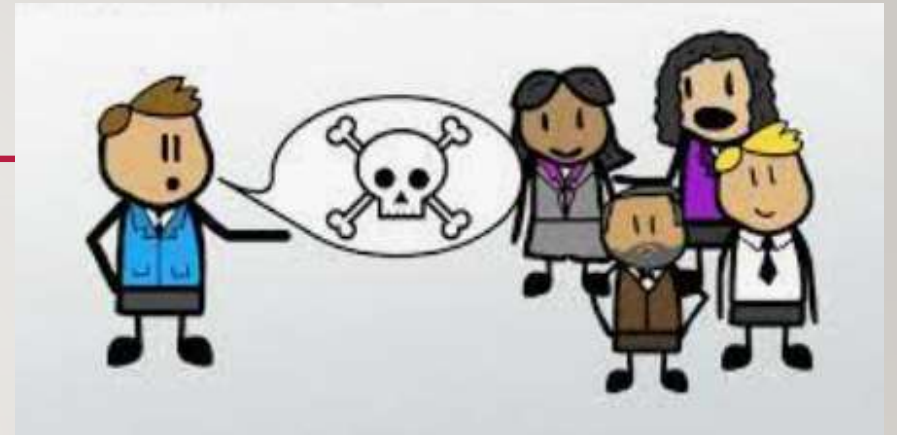
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**Reward Power** - agent's ability to control the rewards that the target wants

**Coercive Power** - agent's ability to cause an unpleasant experience for a target if the target does not comply

**Legitimate Power** - agent and target agree that agent has influential rights, based on position and mutual agreement

**Information Power** – Derived from access to and control over information e.g access to data



# SOURCES OF ORGANIZATIONAL POWER: INFORMAL / PERSONAL POWER

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- **Referent Power** – develops out of admiration and desire to be like an individual
- **Expert Power** – Influence derived out of special skill or knowledge





# ORGANIZATIONAL POLITICS

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# ORGANIZATIONAL POLITICS

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- Organizational **politics** refers to the activities employees undertake in the workplace to gain power and achieve desired outcomes.
- Refers to the agenda of each employee within a company and the activities they engage in to acquire, increase, and wield power and resources to gain a desired outcome.

# IMPACTS OF ORGANIZATIONAL POLITICS ON EMPLOYEES

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- Decrease in overall productivity
- Affects Concentration
- Spoils the Ambience
- Changes the Attitude of employees
- Increases Stress and Burnout
- Increases Turnover

# DEFENSIVE BEHAVIOUR IN ORGANIZATIONS

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- Defensive behaviour refers to actions taken by employees to **protect themselves from criticism, blame, or threats** rather than addressing the real issue or problem.
- In organizational settings, employees may try to **avoid responsibility, justify mistakes, or shift blame** when they feel that their image, position, or performance is under threat.

# THREE DIMENSIONS OF DEFENSIVE BEHAVIOUR

- Organizational behaviour research often describes **three common forms (dimensions) of defensive behaviour**.
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- **I. Avoiding Action:**

Employees try to **avoid taking action on a problem** to prevent criticism or responsibility.

- Instead of solving the issue, they delay or ignore it.

- **Common behaviours**

- Ignoring problems
- Delaying decisions
- Passing responsibility to others
- Pretending the issue does not exist

Eg: A project manager notices that a project deadline will not be met but **avoids informing senior management** to escape blame.





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- **2.Avoiding Blame**

Employees try to **protect themselves from being blamed** if something goes wrong.

- They attempt to **shift responsibility to others or external factors**.

- **Common behaviours**

- Blaming colleagues
- Blaming external conditions
- Providing excuses
- Over-documenting work to prove innocence

**Example:**

If a product fails in the market, a marketing manager may blame the **production department or market conditions** instead of accepting responsibility.



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## 3. Avoiding Change

Employees resist or avoid change because they fear **failure, uncertainty, or loss of control**.

- They prefer the **status quo**, even when change is necessary.
- **Common behaviours**
- Resisting new technology
- Opposing new policies
- Criticizing new initiatives
- Saying “this is how we always do it”

### Example:

Employees in a company resist adopting **digital systems** because they fear they may not be able to learn the new technology.



# IMPRESSION MANAGEMENT

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- Impression management is the process by which individuals attempt to control the impressions that others form of them

# IMPRESSION MANAGEMENT TECHNIQUES

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**1. Conformity:** Agreeing with someone else's opinion in order to gain his or her approval.

- Example: A manager tells his boss, "You are absolutely right on your reorganization plan for the western regional office. I couldn't agree with you more."

## **2. Favors**

Doing something nice for someone to gain that person's approval.

*Example:* A salesperson says to a prospective client, "I've got two tickets to the theater tonight that I can't use. Take them. Consider it a thank-you for taking the time to talk with me."



# IMPRESSION MANAGEMENT TECHNIQUES

## 3. Excuses

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Explanations of a predicament-creating event aimed at minimizing the apparent severity of the Predicament.

*Example:* A sales manager says to her boss, “We failed to get the ad in the paper on time, but no one responds to those ads anyway.”

## 4. Apologies

Admitting responsibility for an undesirable event and simultaneously seeking to get a pardon for the action.

*Example:* An employee says to his boss, “I’m sorry I made a mistake on the report. Please forgive me.”

# IMPRESSION MANAGEMENT TECHNIQUES

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## 5. Self-Promotion

Highlighting one's best qualities, downplaying one's deficits, and calling attention to one's achievements.

*Example:* A salesperson tells his boss, "Matt worked unsuccessfully for three years to try to get that account. I sewed it up in six weeks. I'm the best closer this company has."

## 6. Enhancement

Claiming that something you did is more valuable than most other members of the organizations would think .

*Example:* A journalist tells his editor, "My work on this celebrity divorce story was really a major boost to our sales" (even though the story only made it to page 3 in the entertainment section)

# IMPRESSION MANAGEMENT TECHNIQUES

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## 7. Flattery

Complimenting others about their virtues in an effort to make oneself appear perceptive and likeable.

*Example:* A new sales trainee says to her peer, “You handled that client’s complaint so tactfully! I could never have handled that as well as you did.”

## 8. Exemplification

Doing more than you need to in an effort to show how dedicated and hard working you are.

*Example:* An employee sends e-mails from his work computer when he works late so that his supervisor will know how long he’s been working.